

FROM PORTUGAL Sempre Fado—a highlight of the Serendipity Arts Festival in Goa

ARTS ▼

CELEBRATING CULTURE

To celebrate a decade of SERENDIPITY ARTS FESTIVAL, a Mini Edition in Birmingham is the first in a series of global engagements

In a first, Serendipity Arts Festival—one of South Asia's most recognised multidisciplinary arts festivals—makes its way to Birmingham for a Mini Edition. Scheduled from May 23-26, the event—organised in collaboration with Birmingham City University (BCU)—is a concentrated yet immersive experience of the flagship festival held in Goa every year. "The Mini Edition is an opportunity to engage with the Festival's spirit in new geographies and forge new cultural connections leading up to the milestone celebration in December," says Smriti Rajgarhia, Director, Serendipity Arts Foundation.

A pivotal reason behind choosing Birmingham, says Rajgarhia, is the city's openness to cultural experimentation. Besides, Serendipity has a longstanding relationship with BCU. "The University has been a deeply collaborative partner, and their spaces—from the Royal Birmingham Conservatoire to the symphony hall—offered the ideal infrastructure to host this cross-cultural initiative," adds Rajgarhia.

One of the highlights of the Mini Edition is 'Thumri in the Chamber', which reimagines the Hindustani form of thumri through an interdisciplinary lens—merging it with contemporary arrangements and presenting it in a chamber concert format. There's also a two-part tribute and a celebration of Ustad Zakir Hussain's legacy: a special screening of *The Speaking Hand*, a documentary by Sumantra Ghosal, will be followed by a conversation featuring Ghosal, Dayanita Singh and other collaborators of Hussain.



THE MINI EDITION IN BIRMINGHAM WILL HAVE A TRIBUTE AND CELEBRATION OF USTAD ZAKIR HUSSAIN'S LEGACY

The Birmingham edition will include a repertoire of performances, exhibitions, workshops and cross-cultural dialogues. For Rajgarhia, the idea is not just to replicate the Goa festival, but to co-create contextually relevant experiences that draw from both local and South Asian cultural vocabularies. ■

—Geetika Sachdev